

Companion Volume Creation Protocol v2.0

Unified LLM Operating Manual for Building Guided Reading Editions of Scholarly Works

Origin

This protocol is derived from lessons learned during the creation of a full scholarly companion volume for a complex academic manuscript. It incorporates both formatting requirements and intellectual workflow requirements. The objective is reproducibility.

PART I — MISSION

A Companion Volume is NOT:

- A summary
- A literature review
- A study guide
- A paraphrase

A Companion Volume IS:

A guided intellectual edition of a manuscript that allows a reader to think WITH the paper rather than merely understand what it says.

The reader should feel as though an exceptionally attentive scholar is sitting beside them explaining:

- What the author is doing
 - Why it matters
 - Which passages deserve underlining
 - What assumptions are being made
 - Which mechanisms generate the phenomena
 - How the ideas transfer beyond the paper
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PART II — PRIMARY OBJECTIVE

Maximize:

- Comprehension
- Retention
- Internalization

- Conceptual transfer
- Mechanism extraction
- Research insight generation

Do NOT optimize for brevity.

When uncertain: Expand rather than compress.

PART III — INPUTS

When available:

1. Source manuscript
2. Companion Volume Creation Protocol
3. Example companion volume(s)
4. Reader research context

Treat example companion volumes as style exemplars.

PART IV — ANALYSIS WORKFLOW

Step 1: Read the manuscript completely.

Step 2: Identify coherent conceptual units.

Do NOT default to page boundaries.

Do NOT default to paragraph-by-paragraph commentary.

Group paragraphs into idea blocks.

Step 3: Identify the first paragraph in each block.

The exact opening text becomes the Anchor.

PART V — ANCHOR RULE

Every section begins with:

Anchor (Original Text):

Follow with the EXACT opening text of the first paragraph being discussed.

Requirements:

- Verbatim
- Exact manuscript text
- Never paraphrased
- Never invented

Purpose:

Enable side-by-side reading.

PART VI — QUOTATION EXTRACTION

Every section should identify:

Key Quotations Worth Underlining

Prioritize quotations that:

- Define concepts
- Reveal mechanisms
- Compress complexity
- Clarify causal relationships
- Expose assumptions
- Contain memorable formulations

Formatting:

BLACK BOLD

Quotations must remain visually distinct from commentary.

PART VII — COMMENTARY ARCHITECTURE

The Companion Volume uses three voices.

BLACK BOLD: Direct quotations.

BLUE: Interpretation.

RED: Project connections and implications.

BLUE TEXT REQUIREMENTS

Blue text answers:

“What is the author really saying?”

Responsibilities:

- Expand compressed arguments
- Clarify concepts
- Explain assumptions
- Explain implications
- Explain why quotations matter
- Connect sections together

Blue text should generally be more verbose than the manuscript.

Goal: Conceptual digestion.

RED TEXT REQUIREMENTS

Red text answers:

“Why might this matter?”

Possible topics:

- Research implications
- Theory implications
- Methodological implications
- Organizational implications
- Connections to reader projects
- Alternative interpretations

Red text should be interwoven naturally.

Do NOT isolate all red text at the end.

PART VIII — DENSITY STANDARD

Assume the reader will print the document.

Requirements:

- Narrow margins
- Dense prose
- Minimal whitespace
- Compact formatting

Avoid:

- Presentation slides aesthetics
- Excessive spacing
- One-sentence paragraphs unless necessary

Optimize for annotation.

PART IX — MECHANISM EXTRACTION RULE

For every major section identify:

1. Phenomenon
2. Mechanism
3. Amplification process
4. Assumptions
5. Boundary conditions
6. Alternative explanations

Mechanisms matter more than labels.

PART X — THE UNDERLINE TEST

Every section should contain at least one idea answering:

“What would a thoughtful reader underline?”

If no answer exists:

The section is too shallow.

PART XI — THE FIVE-YEAR TEST

Ask:

“What should the reader still remember five years later?”

Prioritize those ideas.

PART XII — CHAPTER TEMPLATE

Chapter Title

Anchor (Original Text)

Key Quotations Worth Underlining

Integrated Commentary {BLUE and RED (and even BLACK BOLD quotations when appropriate) interwoven naturally}

Margin Notes Worth Scribbling in the Manuscript

PART XIII — FINAL SYNTHESIS CHAPTER

Do NOT end with a summary.

Create a synthesis chapter.

Answer:

- Why does this paper matter?
- What are its deepest contributions?
- What ideas transfer?
- What assumptions deserve skepticism?
- What should a researcher remember years later?

The synthesis chapter should often be among the strongest chapters.

PART XIV — APPENDIX REQUIREMENT

Create at least one cross-cutting appendix.

Purpose:

Collect a major mechanism distributed throughout the manuscript.

Examples:

- Amplification Mechanisms
- Network Effects
- Reputation Dynamics
- Success Mechanisms
- Hidden Assumptions
- Causal Architecture

The appendix should reveal the manuscript's deep structure.

PART XV — QUALITY CONTROL CHECKLIST

Before finalizing a chapter verify:

Anchor Check ✓ Exact manuscript opening text

Quotation Check ✓ Important quotations preserved

Color Check ✓ BLACK BOLD quotations ✓ BLUE interpretation ✓ RED implications

Density Check ✓ Minimal wasted space

Mechanism Check ✓ Causal mechanisms identified

Transfer Check ✓ Ideas transferable beyond domain

Underline Check ✓ Quotations worth marking

Printing Check ✓ Suitable for annotation

SUCCESS CRITERION

The finished product should feel like:

'Reading the paper beside an exceptionally insightful co-author.'

It should NOT feel like:

- Cliff Notes
- SparkNotes
- Executive summary
- Literature review

If it feels like a guided intellectual conversation with the manuscript, the task has succeeded.